

How key signatures work

Key signatures are written before time signatures on the staff. Unlike time signatures, which are only written at the beginning of the first line on the staff, key signatures are written at the beginning of every new line. Once a key signature has indicated which notes are to be played as sharps or flats, there is no need to write a sharp or flat sign next to those notes. The exception to this is after an accidental (a sharp or flat outside the key signature) has been used in a bar.

The key signature has four flats, and shows that this music is in A $\flat$ major.

The key signature shows that B should be played as B $\flat$.

The key signature shows that A should be played as A $\flat$.

▽ Key signature with flats

The music below is in A $\flat$ major. The key signature indicates that the notes B, E, A, and D should be played as flats, so there is no need to write the flat sign next to them.

The key signature has one sharp, and shows that this music is in G major.

C $\sharp$ is not in the key signature, so the sharp here needs to be written into the music.

The key signature shows that F should be played as F $\sharp$.

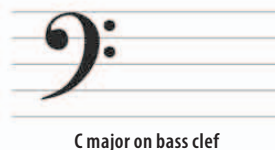
▽ Key signature with a sharp

The music below is in G major and its key signature indicates that F should be played as F $\sharp$, so there is no need to write the sharp sign next to it. However, where other notes are sharp, a sharp sign is needed.

LOOKING CLOSER

What about C major?

Because a C major scale has no sharps or flats, the C major key signature has no sharps or flats written in it. If music is in a major key and doesn't have any sharps or flats in its key signature, that means it is in C major.



▷ On the staff

This is how the key signature for C major—with no sharps or flats—is written on the treble, bass, alto, and tenor clefs.

If a piece of music does not have a **descriptive title**, its **key** can become an **important part** of its title. A famous example is **Elgar's Cello Concerto in E minor**.